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Bernard Lonergan, Intellectual Conversion, and Authentic Love

Perhaps more than any other thinker, Bernard Lonergan is able to appropriate from the past and the present. He develops sophisticated readings of Augustine and Aquinas, in conversation with Kant and Heidegger, to provide a phenomenology of the concrete subject based in the primacy of the human subject as a loving, desiring being. From this account Lonergan derives a full vision of human knowing, being, and acting that would guide education in its cultural, civilizational, and transformational aspirations. Augustine, Aquinas, Heidegger, Taylor, and Lonergan provide a vision of the human being as lover, and this vision gives a normative task to Christian education. But, of course, this integral vision is disrupted by sin.

WHAT IS TRUTH?

For a university to be a university, it must wrestle with the question of truth. Yet it seems more natural today to ask, “Whose truth?” rather than to speak of “the truth.” And there are good reasons for this. Relativism does not merely spring from decades of advertisement-laden media saturation and the doublespeak of political spin-doctors. The question arises from our everyday experience of finding out how differently our neighbors think of things. Anyone who has ever been immersed in a cross-cultural situation will likely testify to the disorienting experience of having one’s intuitions and assumptions be largely wrong. And in today’s university, the cross-cultural experience may well come from our neighbors.

The modern philosophical tradition further complicates the question of truth. Immanuel Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*, probably the most influential philosophical work of the last two centuries, argues that we have no knowledge of reality as it is in itself, but only of reality as it is perceived.¹ Many of the relativistic understandings of truth, adverted to above, knowingly or unknowingly draw on Kant's legacy. But if truth does not concern reality as it is, what remains of the value of the term? But how can a university be a university without teaching about reality?

Bernard Lonergan offers an analysis of this quandary that acknowledges the brilliance and challenges of modern philosophy but which locates the real problem at a much deeper level. According to Lonergan, human beings are naturally beset, based on the type of being that they are, by a persistent and stubborn myth about knowledge. Much modern philosophical training exacerbates this myth. While it is possible to outgrow the myth in a fairly natural progression of human development, overcoming it in a stable and integral way will likely require a radical clarification of our understanding of human knowing.

AUGUSTINE'S DILEMMA

The perennial nature of this struggle can be seen in the intellectual and spiritual pilgrimage of Augustine, already adverted to in this book. In his *Confessions*, he wrestles most of all with the question of who (and what) is the true God.² Perhaps Augustine's main point, as he tells his life story in the *Confessions*, is that in order to know himself he must first know God. And knowing God involves knowing reality, for to know God above all means to know the truth.

In the course of his conversion, Augustine comes up against a very peculiar kind of problem. He wants to believe in God, who is good and incorruptible, but is blocked from this by his conception of God as a body. Even as a very fine kind of light, suffusing all creation—the highest kind of body Augustine could imagine—how could a body truly be incorruptible and good? Every body is subject to motion and change. And if God's being suffuses all reality, why does it not drive evil out? But

1. See Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*; it was not Kant's intention to spawn epistemic relativism—quite the opposite—but there is many a slip 'twixt the cup and the lip.

2. See Augustine, *Confessions*, *passim*.

if God is not a body—without form, without shape, without dimension, without color or shade—is God anything at all? Is God really there?

BEYOND ANIMAL KNOWING

As Lonergan analyzes this dilemma, he believes that Augustine's problems stem from the deep ambivalence within us between animalistic ways of knowing reality, which are most spontaneous for us, and fully human ways of knowing reality, which we must achieve. As animals, we interact with the world as we encounter it and as it is useful to us. Therefore it is perfectly natural for us to seek "bodies": external components of reality that are present and available for us. And we are right to do so, for that which is already out there now, available for us to see or grasp, is essential for us a living, animal beings.³ Yet to interact with reality only in this way, Lonergan argues, is to miss out on the fully human way of knowing reality that, provoked by wonder, goes beyond mere interaction with bodies.⁴

The basis of the myth, Lonergan argues, is that we are both animal beings and something more. And it is easy to confuse the criteria for knowledge in the animal world with that of the higher, spiritual and intellectual, aspects of our being. In Augustine's long-fought victory to know God intellectually, and not as a body, Lonergan sees an authentic person following the lead of wonder to achieve truly human knowing.

When we are following the myth, we assume knowing to be something understandable by an analogy with ocular vision. In other words, "reality" is something we encounter, and knowing reality means to have a direct, or unimpeded, encounter with it. By analogy, we know something when we can see it clearly and distinctly, or (to move to another sensory analogy) when we can have direct contact with it.⁵

This type of knowing does match up quite well with what it means to be a successful animal. Sensitive animal existence has most concern

3. For example, what feeds me is the plate of spaghetti, hot and tasty, present now for me on the table, available for me to stick my fork into. As an animal being, what is important about reality for me is that which is externally present, independent of me, and available for my use.

4. Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, 22.

5. See the discussion of space and time in Lonergan, *Insight*, 163–95, for an explanation of this type of knowing and of the necessity for progressing beyond its valid but limited viewpoint.

for objects as it is able to eat or mate with them, or as they present threats. What the robin cares about, within the limits of its animal psychology, is the worm as a body: present, out-there now, available to eat. Or, during mating season, it cares about the robin of the opposite gender; and at all times the snake slithering toward it is of concern. The idea of the snake and the intellectual appropriation of the worm are not biologically useful. That which is “out there now” is.

KNOWING BEING

With respect to this animal aspect of presence and usefulness, the idea or intelligibility can seem to be something distinct from and derivative of the really real bodily presence of the thing. What interests me is the food, mate, or threat that is “really out there.” The idea of the thing, on the contrary, is more nebulous. From this viewpoint, it can seem to reside “in my head.”

Knowing an object, then, would seem to mean abstracting an adequate idea of it from experiencing the reality of the thing. For example, truly to know the plate of spaghetti that I am about to eat means to have formed an adequate idea of it based on my encounter with it. I would know it if in fact it is the plate of spaghetti I think it is, and not a cleverly disguised pile of string or worms.

In this paradigm, objectivity amounts to unimpeded contact, or direct encounter, of a thing. Again the analogy of ocular vision is instructive. If we can see something clearly and distinctly, we have an unimpeded presence of the thing to us. We know it objectively because we have a true view of it. Subjectivity creeps in when either we are unable to see the thing clearly, or when some aspect of our vision keeps us from encountering it as it really is out there.

Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* devastatingly attacks exactly this understanding of knowledge. As he cogently argues, our perceiving of a thing is not an act distinct from us who are doing the perceiving, but is a creative act in itself. Therefore, when we are speaking of encounter with reality, we are more properly speaking not of the reality that is encountered but of our experience of it. For what we have direct access to are our perceptions. Because Kant agreed with this notion of knowledge, he concluded that humans have no objective knowledge of reality.⁶ There

6. See Kant's discussion of the transcendental aesthetic in the *Critique of Pure Reason* for a discussion of space and time on these terms. Kant did believe that we have

is no unimpaired view of objects, because our perception itself must be accounted for as a limiting factor.

According to Lonergan, a deep similarity exists between this notion of knowledge, which Kant both espouses and problematizes, and the notion of God as a body, which Augustine struggled to overcome. In both cases, reality is something “already out there now.” Augustine’s breakthrough came when he realized that the presence and reality of God has more the character of a truth that is known than the character of a body that is encountered.⁷

To know a truth means to know a meaning, and the reality of the thing known is mediated to us through that meaning. Truth and meaning are not limited (or even describable) in spatial terms, as bodies are. They can mediate spatial reality to us, but themselves are neither intrinsically “in here” nor “out there.” What Augustine discovered is that with respect to the reality he was trying to know (the highest reality, that of God), he would be successful not by finding God somewhere out there, but by contemplating the meanings that mediated God’s being to him. In this way, the criterion for knowing reality is not the directness of our encounter with it but the correctness of the meanings that mediate being to us.

The world as known by a successful animal is real and important, but it is only a fragment of the world known in a fully human way. The myth that human knowledge is so easily subject to is that all knowing must conform to the criteria of animalistic knowing. But when human beings speak of the real world, they mean a world far wider than animalistic knowing-by-encounter can explain.

The real world, as we almost always mean it, is a world mediated to us by sets of meanings and partially constituted by meanings. It includes mathematical, physical, chemical, biological, psychological, intellectual and spiritual aspects of reality. Within it are such things as triangles, momentum, oxygen, trees, cats, families, and prayer. All of these realities have meaning and intelligibility as a basic component. In other words, their meanings are not extrinsic add-ons, applied to the underlying reality of things, which underlying true reality and being may or may not be

objective knowledge of these perceptions, and he attributed the certainty achieved in mathematics and the natural sciences to this objectivity. Things as they are in themselves, however, are unknown to us.

7. Augustine, *Confessions*, Book 7.

knowable to us. Rather, the reality of things—their being—is known by and through those sets of meanings.

Take, for example, the reality of a family. If reality conforms to the expectations of animalistic knowing, does a family exist? Where is it? One can encounter the individual people, but look as we might, no family will be found. It would seem that “family” is just a concept in our minds that we use to group the really existing people. But when we speak of the real world, we often especially mean the world in which we have relationships and responsibilities, such as a family. In fully human knowing, as Lonergan explains it, families have real existence. They are intelligible realities that one can know by following the drive of wonder and asking and answering questions. They are not bodies in the external world that one can find. But the point is that by knowing families we know something true, an aspect of the real world mediated to us through meanings.

As opposed to a family, something like oxygen would seem to have a different status in terms of being known and really existing. After all, oxygen is “really out there now.” You can find it, grasp it, and encounter it. There is, of course, a difference. A family is composed of human acts of meaning; our understandings, judgments, and subsequent decisions and actions constitute the reality of it. Oxygen is not constituted of human acts of meaning in the same way.

And yet, oxygen, in its being and existence, is mediated to us (known by us) through human acts of meaning. No one knows oxygen by direct encounter alone. We encounter the pressure and bodily need for air, yet for most of human existence we had no knowledge that a special element called oxygen existed. Joseph Priestly deduced its existence in 1774, and Antoine Lavoisier gave its current name to it in 1777. The closest any human can currently come to directly grasping oxygen, perhaps, would be in the readouts of an electron microscope. In this case, a number of scans of the distortion of electron wavelengths are averaged to correlate to an image that would correspond to what we would see in visual light.

But this is not the way we really know oxygen. We know it in its relation to other elements on the periodic table. We know it in its relation to acts of combustion (the way Lavoisier was able to know and name it, disproving an earlier theory of how combustion occurs). We know it in the bars of color it produces in a visible spectrum analysis,

related to other sets of color bars produced by other elements. We do know it through the readouts of the electron microscope, but we know it therein as it is related to aspects of visible light and to the way other elements' readouts are correlated to visible light. We know it in the life-giving function oxygen has for animal life. In other words we know the being of oxygen through sets of meanings that mediate its being to us. When Priestly and Lavoisier made their breakthrough discoveries, we knew the truth about a new aspect of reality. The meanings are therefore not add-ons; rather, we know the real being of oxygen through them; the real being of oxygen is an intelligible reality.

The mediation of being through human acts of meaning in such realities as families and oxygen can help us understand the way we know other realities that we can grasp and feel. What are we doing when we know something we seemingly can grasp, such as the family cat? Is it really the case that the "stuff" of the cat—the base materials of the fur and claws, flesh and bones—is the reality of the cat, and the ideas we have about the cat are add-ons that we supply? Conversely, are those ideas all that are worth talking about as a "cat," in some way independent of, or unknowably related to, the real being of the cat?

In either of these cases, we have to ignore some data about the cat, ruling irrelevant significant insights that we actually do have and function with. One of the scientific names for a cat is *felix domesticus*. Indicated in that name is a significant relation by which we know what it is that we are talking about: a connection with our home, or *domus*. This connection places the cat also relative to non-domesticated species of cats. Whether or not a particular *felix domesticus* is in fact domesticated, it is the kind of cat that often does become incorporated into human society. Other species of cats (for example, *wildcats* or *cougars*) would become so only sporadically. The argument is not that human society has changed the being of *felix domesticus*, putting its mark upon it (although it has). The point is that we know something significant about the cat in terms of its ability to form a part of our societies and the actuality of its regularly doing so.

The reality of the family cat, as with the rest of the real world, is mediated to us through sets of meanings. These meanings are commonly (and perhaps always) known as sets of relations to other realities we know in the world. The cat is an animal, related to other animals such as bears, butterflies, and barracudas. The cat is domesticated, related in

ways that can be specified to a particular aspect of human society, to other domesticated animals, and to non-domesticated animals. The cat is a mammal and a fairly strict carnivore, placing it in relation to other sets of living beings and eating practices. A particular cat might be a family's cat, placing it in particular reference to a set of human beings. These sets of meanings are not merely add-ons that we supply, nor are they disconnected from the being of the cat. Rather we know the reality of the cat through these sets of relations. In some cases, the sets of relations are constituted by human acts of meaning, in some cases human acts of meaning discover them.⁸

CRITERIA OF OBJECTIVITY

One can thereby see that the criteria of objectivity for the world mediated by meaning (the real world, known humanly) differ markedly from those of the world of merely animalistic knowing. In the world of merely animalistic knowing, immediate presence is the hallmark of objectivity. Can you grab it, see it, and experience it in a direct and unimpeded way? In the world mediated by meaning (that is, in the real world), experience is still present and basic, and it must be truly attentive to the reality experienced. Experience is only a start, however, for on the basis of our experiences, we wonder. The path of genuine knowledge follows that wonder.

Objectivity thereby comes to mean being authentic to your experiences and yourself as an inquirer. Do we ask questions about our experience and form concepts that meet its exigencies, intelligently considered? Do we assess those concepts reasonably, assessing which of them, if any, are supported by evidence? Do we come to a grasp of sufficient evidence (either probably or certainly) to warrant assent that one of those conceptions is actually the case?

When we follow through with the call of wonder, culminating in the real gift of self in love, we are true to the basic character of our being. Lonergan, therefore, named four "transcendental precepts:" be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible.⁹ Obeying these precepts means following through with the immanent norms of our own

8. For a more technical discussion of human knowing, see Snell, *Though a Glass Darkly*.

9. See Lonergan, *Method*, 20, 53, and 55.

experiencing, understanding, judging, and deciding being. Failing to do so means to fail to be who we really are. In his account of human knowing and deciding, Lonergan does not neglect the results of human acts of cognition—they are obviously crucial—but especially wants to show what it means for the process of human cognition to go right. The transcendental precepts explain what that procedural rightness is; and, that rectitude consists not of buckling under to an external standard (though there may be legitimate external standards) but rather giving free reign to the requirements of the ongoing motion and action of our own being when we seek to know and love.

By following the lead of wonder—attentively, intelligently, reasonably—we can come to correct understandings of the experiences that we have. And in coming to correct understandings, we come to knowledge of the world. For the real world is mediated to us not by encounter alone but by the meanings through which we explain the reality that we encounter.¹⁰

Lonergan calls the transition from more animalistic ways of knowing to fully human knowing, which Augustine made with respect to knowledge of God, “intellectual conversion” or “intellectual self-transcendence.”¹¹ It is expected to occur naturally as humans come to adulthood. However, the character of this spontaneous conversion is unstable; true virtue is not accidental, but must be earned. It is especially vulnerable to the course of philosophical study. As he says:

It occurs spontaneously when one reaches the age of reason, implicitly drops earlier criteria of reality (Are you awake? Do you see it? Is it heavy? etc.), and proceeds to operate on the criteria of sufficient evidence or sufficient reason. But this spontaneous conversion is insecure. The use of the earlier criteria can recur. It is particularly likely to recur when one gets involved in philosophical issues. For then the objectification of what is meant by sufficient evidence or sufficient reason may become exceedingly complex, while the objectification of getting a good look is simplicity itself.¹²

10. See the chapter on “Self-Affirmation of the Knower” in Lonergan, *Insight*, 343–71.

11. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 114; see also Lonergan, “Self-Transcendence: Intellectual, Moral, Religious.”

12. Lonergan, “Unity and Plurality,” 248.

In knowing the real world through inquiry and a grasp of sufficient evidence, one comes to adulthood in terms of what it means to know the world. One has rejected (either explicitly or implicitly) the myth that knowing the world is constituted by encounter alone and come to terms with the objectivity that comes from a grasp of sufficient reason. If this transition happens in a thorough and stable way, one has radically clarified the human relation to truth.¹³

The concern persists that knowledge which may be wrong cannot rightly be described as knowledge (or, what is to say the same thing, as objectively valid). We are finite beings, and even our most intelligent and reasonable affirmations cannot preclude the possibility of further relevant questions someday arising. Authenticity is good, but does it really measure up as a criterion for what objective knowing is supposed to be?

To put it bluntly, it seems that under Lonergan's analysis, objective human knowing can sometimes be wrong. The criteria of authenticity do not produce the kind of apodictic certainty we desire. If something might not be true, how can one claim to know it? Are we not claiming that sometimes a person has knowledge but is in fact wrong? And is that not a contradiction in terms?¹⁴

Our answer is we are trying to understand human knowing, and that infallible knowing does not seem to be a merely human possibility. By claiming an infallible truth, one is claiming the kind of permanence of judgment that cannot ever be changed. But the affirmation, "Heaven and earth may pass away, but my judgment will never pass away," is not a statement that we believe can rightly be made on merely human terms. It is, in fact, to claim the knowledge of a god.

To hold human knowledge to that standard would be to say that in order to know something, a human must become a god. It seems to me that Kant (and Nietzsche) both do hold humans to that standard. Because human knowing cannot measure up to that standard, it is therefore nothing, or at least a radically limited thing with respect to knowing the real world. But the fact that we have built civilizations (or that we can

13. For a readable explanation of Lonergan's project by one of his first students, see Flanagan, *Quest for Self-Knowledge*.

14. Mortimer Adler puts the expectation this way: "Opinions can be true or false. Opinions can be right or wrong. We all recognize this, I think. But think a moment, knowledge can't be false, knowledge can't be wrong. If something is knowledge it's impossible for it to be false knowledge or wrong knowledge." Adler, *How to Think About the Great Ideas*, 14.

have this particular argument at all) seems to me to testify to the validity of human forms of knowing.

The right foundation of fully human knowledge, then, is humility. Knowledge on fully human terms (but conversely, on merely human terms) must admit that its judgments are not certain in the way a divine pronouncement is. Fully human knowledge resolutely claims that in correct understanding we know the real world. But it is still we, we finite ones, we human ones, that are doing the knowing. Our knowing is valid, but we have not yet come to complete knowledge of the universe. Being authentic to ourselves as questioners means including this confident but humble awareness in all our answers.

THOMAS ON WISDOM AND CHARITY

Even if one accepts what we have described as “fully human knowing” as valid, however, significant questions can remain as to whether our actual human cognitional process matches up to the criteria of objectivity given above. Are we in fact ever attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible in a way that yields valid knowledge of the world? What guarantees that we will live up to our part of the bargain?

When Thomas Aquinas considered the problem of knowing reality, the widest terms under which he did so were those of wisdom. Wisdom, in Thomas’ understanding, might be called the habit of reality. That is, wisdom is able to assess both the correctness of one’s knowledge of the world (Is what I know about the world really true?) and the rectitude of one’s processes of knowing the world (Am I knowing the world in the right way?).¹⁵ The wise person is the one who can get knowledge right in both these ways. While wisdom does therefore boil down to a kind of knowledge, it is a regulating kind. It has not so much connected with specific inquiries as to the relation of the whole and the rightness of the knower with respect to that whole.

In that light, it is striking that Thomas so strongly connects wisdom with love. While charity (the supernatural gift of love) is the form of all the virtues, wisdom specifically springs from charity.¹⁶ In other words, because the saved person has received the gift of friendship with God, he is able to know God’s creation on different, more realistic, terms. He

15. *ST II-II* 45.6.

16. *ST II-II* 45.6 *re. ad. 2.*

does not necessarily become an expert in any aspect of human knowledge, but is in fact better able to judge the adequacy of human knowing because he is connected in friendship with the source of all and orderer of the whole.

But why would love make such a difference for knowledge? Knowing seems to be one thing, while loving seems to be another; we can even refer to love as “blind.” It seems one could be a deeply loving person, but still not very knowledgeable. While Thomas’ connection of wisdom and charity seems attractive, will it not fall short of answering the questions with which we started? For it seems that love, as we ordinarily conceive it, is a poor tool to guarantee the correctness of our knowledge of the world.

The answer to these questions begins with the insight that reason—the way we know the world—is not an instrument or tool that we use, but rather it is we, ourselves, as we interact genuinely with the world. Furthermore, neither is love a tool; it is we, our self-transcendent selves, as we live in openness and friendship toward the world. Thomas did not have a modern, instrumental, view of reason and love. He saw them as integral to the operations of our being.

HEIDEGGER ON SELVES AND WORLD

As we have already discussed, one of the most powerful modern opponents of the instrumental view of reason and love is the German philosopher Martin Heidegger. To understand the way we can appropriate Thomas’ insight within the modern context, it will be helpful to review an aspect of Heidegger’s work. In particular, his notions of Care and Mood serve as useful ways to interpret and understand the validity of Thomas’ linking of wisdom and charity.¹⁷

Heidegger, again, argues that successfully to understand our existence we will need to take note of the way we are always already within a linguistically and culturally charged historical setting. Within this context, our existence has the character of an event. We are present within this context in an active way, and in fact, we are more successful in understanding our existence if we see this active and situated “Being-There”

17. See Thiselton, *Two Horizons*, 192, on the ontological status of mood (or State-of-Mind) in both Tillich and Heidegger.

as intrinsic to who we are.¹⁸ In other words, the nature of our identity is not that of a static substance, considered abstractly and disconnected from a world, but our very existence involves Being-in-the-World.

As those whose being is “Being-There,” and “Being-in-the World,” existence has the character of a challenge and a risk. The challenge of our existence is to become and find our true identity. Because we are enmeshed in a world, the character of the world always has the potential to cover over our own true selves. We can become lost in purposeless activity, in idle chatter, in sets of meanings and values that are not our own but are merely absorbed by us. Hence the risk that instead of becoming authentic selves we will lose ourselves to the crowd, to the average everydayness of routine and purposeless activity.

For our world is a set of relations, and these relations are not extrinsic to us but constitutive of our selves. The tasks and purposes we have constitute the nature of our event, our Being-There. Heidegger characterizes human existence as “essentially teleological; in each of our actions we express goals which point outward to some sense of our lives as a final, definitive configuration of meaning. . . . I make a commitment, whether consciously or not, concerning my overview of what my life amounts to as a totality—concerning what kind of person I am.”¹⁹ This commitment both characterizes and constitutes our being.

The fundamental constitutive aspect of human existence, then, is care, or concern. Our values and motivation indicate and convey concern, and they indicate the way that our existence is enmeshed in a world revealed to us by that concern. Care, or concern, gives substance and direction to our existence. In a way, it is our existence. For who and what we really are—the nature of our event—becomes manifest in the way that interest and value move us. The aspects of the world that do not connect to us through concern, in a real way, are not really “the world” for us. But in the purposes we have in life, revealed and existing in the care that we have, we truly have a world and become alive in it.

By care, as we have already explained, Heidegger means much more than individual instances of concern. The shape of our lives is set by care. The analysis of care reveals to us that have a basic underlying “mood,” or orientation, according to which we respond to the world and

18. Besides Heidegger’s own work, which we have already referred to, see also Braham, *Meaning and Authenticity*, 8–17.

19. Guignon, “Heidegger’s ‘Authenticity’ Revisited,” 331.

that orders the rest of our concern. Our affective being has a shape, direction, or contour that indicates the basic attitude we have toward the world. Are we open and receptive to new encounters, seeking the truth whatever form it might take? Do we close ourselves off, admitting the value of only a restricted portion of the world of being? These questions, and their answers, convey the way that we are able to relate to the world in which we are enmeshed. One could even refer to “mood”—this underlying affective orientation—as an ‘ontological disposition’ in which the event of our being is constituted by the overall shape of our concern.²⁰

Far from being a factor in our lives or a tool we use, then, charity turns out to speak to the constitution of our very selves. For charity, in Aquinas’ terms, is first of all a habit—an ontological disposition—that forms the basis for the way we bring our existence into actuality. As beings constituted by enmeshment in a world, love finds a way for that enmeshment to be right, for our own true selves to be rightly related in this world.

TAYLOR ON SITUATED REASON

The Canadian philosopher Charles Taylor significantly develops Heidegger’s basic insight on the way that we are selves by being part of a world. In *Being and Time*, Heidegger investigated his intuition of our enmeshment in a world—our Being-There—very thoroughly, but in a way that ultimately cuts us off from the self-transcendence we seek. The ultimate horizon of our being, of our world, is death; we are living most authentically when we realize and resolutely live toward our coming dissolution.²¹ The “mood,” or ontological disposition, Heidegger deals with is in fact a very dark thing: “keeping watch on the fire in the night,” as he put it in a discourse to his students. Because he deals only with the self in terms of the categories of finitude and of what is available to us as enmeshed in this world, it is difficult to see any other ultimate end. Taylor, however, seeks to validate Heidegger’s insight about our Being-in-a-World but to do so in a way that discovers sources for a self that truly is moral and self-transcendent. To situate Aquinas’ affirmation of wisdom, we will also reexamine an aspect of Taylor’s thought.

20. Braman, *Meaning and Authenticity*, 16, quoting Richardson, *Heidegger*, 34.

21. Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 299–311.

According to Taylor, the fact that we exist only as those who are enmeshed in a world means that we are ordered to an ultimate good. Because our lives have the character of an event, it is of intrinsic importance for us as selves whether our event is good, or whether it is lacking. But for our event to be good, we must be living unto some good, directed in the operation of our being toward a higher meaning or greater story.²²

In patterning our lives after an ultimate good, we find the moral basis for who we truly are. To be a human person means to embrace the good. Taylor would argue that Heidegger is right in viewing death as a basic reality of the human situation. But Taylor would also argue that in making it the ultimate last word about the human situation, Heidegger has closed off further relevant questions. In Taylor's analysis, we actually find ourselves not by a concentration on our death, which can be narcissistic and closed off to others, but by our real and conscious connection to a greater good.²³

The ultimate expression of this orientation toward the good is love.²⁴ Not every kind of good can order our lives, but only a good that is capable of being a genuine moral source. Some things, that are good in themselves, are only good because they are ordered to a higher way of life. Freedom, for example, is necessary for the good life but is only itself a good if its use is good. Our freedom can become an absolute evil if we choose to make it so. Freedom becomes a true good when it is actuated in righteous choices. But other kinds of good are ordering goods, the kinds of goods that reveal something of ultimate worth and that draw us to live in line with that. Of these, the highest is love, and in particular the love of God.

To be a self, then, means being a moral being. To be a moral being means that in the event of one's becoming that one is ordered to an ultimate good, a higher story that is capable of drawing one toward real self-transcendence. To be ordered to the highest good—the most authentic source of selfhood—means to be ordered in and by the love of God.

22. Braman, *Meaning and Authenticity*, 38.

23. See Taylor, *Sources of the Self*, 374–81, on the moral and self-constitutive aspect of what he calls the “expressivist turn.”

24. Braman, *Meaning and Authenticity*, 39.

RELIGIOUS CONVERSION AS GROUNDING INTELLECTUAL CONVERSION

The most significant question of our lives, according to Lonergan, is whether we have been captured by God's love. God's love provides the foundational situation for our living as rational beings. It also grounds the horizon within which we live, both providing for its possibility and orienting us within it to ultimate truth and goodness.²⁵

Being captured by God's love, according to Lonergan, can best be understood in the categories of Christian spirituality. In the Ignatian tradition, the only secure basis for making a serious choice in life is the realization that one, oneself, has been chosen by God.²⁶ The mark of this divine election is the love one has toward God. Ignatius does not here mean the sincere but limited love prompted by divine gifts and promises. Rather it is the way one finds oneself bound in love toward God in an unlimited way, in a way that is out of proportion to anything in this world to produce or satisfy. Whatever else we know, we know that we can never be the same. On the basis of this love, a love this world cannot provide or satisfy but only God himself, one can make choices that reflect the secure nature of one's place in God.

The love of God, itself the gift of God, places one in a horizon that is quite different from the loss-of-self implied by envelopment in average-everydayness. One's identity has changed because of loving in a way that one could not love before. One experiences a "universal antecedent willingness" to know what is real and choose what is good because openness and self-giving are natural to someone in love. By "natural," Lonergan does not mean "according to the usual run of things for the human species"; rather, the conscious operations of our knowing and choosing have become transformed because of the gift of God's love. In fact, we have begun to love in a way that is more natural for God than for us as a result of God's work within us.

Lonergan terms this most basic change "religious conversion."²⁷ It is a conversion in that it is a change of direction from sinful self-centered-

25. See Lonergan, *Understanding and Being: The Halifax Lectures on "Insight,"* 182. Lonergan's main discussion of horizon in *Method* is in the section, "Horizons," in the chapter "Dialectics." See Lonergan, *Method*, 235–37. See Lonergan, *Method*, 241, for religious conversion as constitutive of horizon.

26. Ignatius Loyola, *Spiritual Exercises*, 205; Lonergan, *Method*, 106.

27. Lonergan, *Method*, 240–41.

ness toward openness to all things (based on openness to, captivation by, God). It is religious in that it is the result of God's work in us. It does not necessarily imply adherence to any of the world's religious traditions. It does imply that one has been changed.

This change is expected by Lonergan to be conscious; it is an aspect of the operation of our consciousness. But that does not mean that this conscious change will be easily apprehended at any single moment. It may be "revealed in retrospect as an under-tow of existential consciousness, as a fated acceptance of a vocation to holiness, as perhaps an increasing simplicity and passivity in prayer."²⁸ The main criterion for religious conversion is not dramatic conversion events (at least, not in any required way) but the change in who one is and how one's conscious operations take place.

Such a transformation has clear ramifications for the nature of one's ethical being. To be oriented within a horizon toward God, the ultimate good, means also to be ordered with a transformed attitude regarding lesser goods (that is, all of the goods in the created world). One does not automatically become a more ethical being, but fundamental changes in one's moral nature have become more probable. Because the true nature of all other goods is to be subordinate to the ultimate Good, namely God, being ordered authentically to God empowers and moves one to live more authentically to the world God has made.²⁹

How, though, does love order intellectual rectitude? The connection with moral transformation seems fairly direct. Love of God, truly having captured one's being, leads one naturally to love what God loves, or to love that which is like God because it bears the imprint of the Creator in its very being. But how does love situate intelligence, and why does this transformed horizon ground our ability to know truth in the world?

Knowledge, according to Lonergan, has an essentially moral character. When we know, we are knowing the being of a thing and may also know its value. But as knowers, we are guided by ethical demands to be attentive to the data we try to understand, inquire and form possible answers to the questions we have in an intelligent way, and affirm or deny the adequacy of those answers reasonably. While the *content* of our knowing is something preliminary to making ethical choices, the *process* of pursuing knowledge is itself a series of ethical choices. For each of the

28. Ibid.

29. Ibid., 291.

conscious operations involved in knowing can be pursued in a way that is either authentic or unauthentic to ourselves as questioning beings and to the nature of the world we are trying to know.

The transformation of our whole conscious being described by religious conversion, therefore, makes more probable the radical clarification of the human process of knowing described above as intellectual conversion. While religious conversion in Lonergan's terms does not necessarily require adherence to any religion, we most authentically understand this transformation in religious terms. But religious doctrines mediate the being and value of the world to us through sets of meanings that we are asked to believe. In believing these meanings, to the extent that the religion in question is true, we know the real world.

Consider, for example, the words of Jesus on the Cross, "It is finished," set forth by the Evangelist in John 19. In Greek, the perfect tense of this declaration does not allow the ambiguity of the English phrase; *tetelestai*, the last word spoken by Jesus before his death, is a victory cry. It means that the goal has been accomplished and that its power endures still. But where, in something "already out there now" is the victory? Having said this word, Jesus breathed his last. Yet this victory declaration does communicate the reality of the Crucifixion. Despite the brutal wrong of the murder of Christ, the victory he sought to win through his incarnation was achieved. One only knows the events on Golgotha rightly if one knows those sets of meanings. In fact, it is by knowing those sets of meanings that one truly knows the death of Christ.

One does not have to be intellectually converted, of course, authentically to be part of a religious tradition in which one responds to and tries to understand one's religious conversion. But the way in which religious doctrines mediate to us the meaning and value of the world does set one up to overcome the myth that knowing is like seeing, that the world is known by us along the analogy of encounter. For the doctrines do not point simply to encounters. They interpret our encounters, giving meaning and value to human experience. The quest to understand what one has received by faith leads, therefore, to an openness to the radical clarification of human knowing that results from realizing what it means to know and to believe.

AUTHENTIC BEING AS BEING-IN-LOVE

Our existence as lovers, then, grounds our existence as choosers and knowers. To express our meaning more fully, the way that God's love has transformed us makes it more likely for us to value what is truly good and know that which is really real. This is so because God's love changes our conscious operations by changing us, the conscious operators. We become authentic knowers and choosers because we have become true to ourselves and true to the Creator of the world in which we know and choose through love.

Authentic Being-in-the-World, then, is Being-in-Love. For in love we are most true to the kinds of beings that we truly are. And the eyes of love, rather than being blind, situate us rightly with respect to the true values of the world. Love maximizes our reasonable being—that is, our knowing and choosing selves—because in love we follow the inner norms of our wonder most fully. Just as we discover and value the world most truly through love, in love we become most fully who we truly are. For the reality of our conscious selves is that we are led by wonder and motivated by the good.

I believe this explanation justifies Aquinas' confidence that the fullness of love effectively grounds the reality of our ability to know the world. Wisdom springs from charity; we habitually come to know the world because we have learned what it means to exist rightly in it. The actuality of love, therefore, grounds and ensures the authenticity of the conscious operations by which we follow wonder and know the truth. Rather than asking whether our minds are able to bridge the gap between ourselves and the world, then, the right question is whether we are rightly situated within the world. That is, do we truly follow the way of love?

However, with this realization in place, it may seem that we have only magnified the problem. It would seem that if a straightforward answer to this question, "Do we truly follow the way of love?" can be given, the answer would be, "No, we do not follow love, or at least not very well." For the reality of human sinfulness shouts to us the manifold nature of our corporate downfall. If we are to take seriously the nature of the love that grounds our knowledge of the truth, and thereby to come to see more clearly the nature of the Christian university's task, we will have to account for the nature of the sin that distorts both our willing and knowing being.